



Instructor: Date:

Learner: Regional Branch:

Program: Center:

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Let's Start!

Pronunciation Spot: Nina wrote songs for the cause!



Learning Outcome

Understand actions, events, and experiences in present, past or future and in spoken or written texts and in work and social contexts.

Can Do Statements

- I can talk about social issues and the arts.
- I can use proper intonation in non-final thought groups.
- I can pronounce vowels in unstressed syllables.

Ask your partner:

- If you could write a song, what would you write about?
- How do you express yourself when you are angry?





Let's Explore!

Nina Simone was known as the **High Priestess*** of Soul.

* A "high priestess" is a female priest who is well respected.



Instructions: Read the text aloud.

Today we will be starting a series of lectures on African-American musicians who shaped our culture and history.

Born on the 21st of February 1933, to the descendants of slaves, Nina Simone became a brilliant musician and an activist in the Civil Rights Movement. After having spent some time at Juilliard studying classical piano, and trying to pay for her life in New York, she ran out of money and went to live in Philadelphia where she applied to the Curtis Institute and was rejected because she was an African-American. This was not the first incident of racism. It was at this point that she turned to jazz and blues ... But, her style was indefinable ... she coined it "African-rooted classical music". Her first album, *Little Girl Blue*, was released in 1958. From then on she recorded copious albums. Her music was powerful, angry ... in live concerts she was intimate, improvisational and raw.

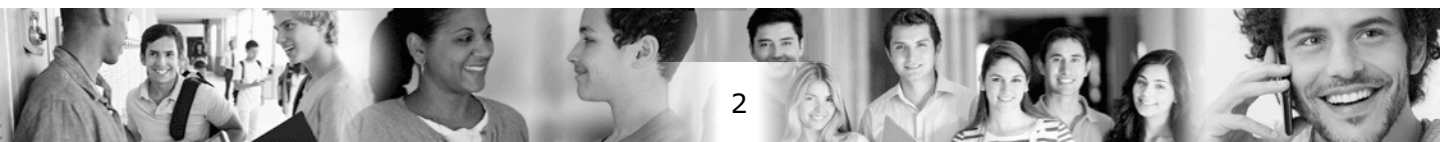
One of her most explosive songs was "Mississippi Goddam", which was written in response to the 1963 bombing of a church in Alabama in which civil rights activist Medgar Evers and four children were killed. The single was boycotted in some of the southern states and this was the first of many songs written for the Civil Rights Movement. As a matter of fact, Nina Simone was proclaimed the voice of the Civil Rights Movement.

"To be Young, Gifted, and Black" was another of her songs written to make black children feel proud and confident of who they were. The anti-lynching ballad "Strange Fruit" is another song she recorded.

When the Civil Rights Movement lost steam, Nina Simone was disheartened and fed up. She led a peripatetic life before settling in the south of France where her mental and physical health declined before she died in 2003. Despite adversity, racism and poverty, Nina Simone left a mark on the world of music.

Maya Angelou wrote, "She is loved or feared, adored or disliked, but few who have met her or glimpsed her soul react with moderation."

Our next lecture will cover the live concerts of Nina Simone.





Let's Practice!

What an interesting woman!

Instructions: Underline all the place names. Read the sentences aloud. Check your pronunciation with your instructor.

1. Today we will be starting a series of lectures on North American musicians who shaped our culture and history.
2. She ran out of money and went to live in Philadelphia with her family.
3. In 1963 there was a bombing of a church in Alabama, in which civil rights activist Medgar Evers was killed.
4. She led a peripatetic life before settling in the south of France.
5. Our next lecture will cover the live concerts of North Carolina's Nina Simone.



Let's Practice!

I love talking about the arts.

Instructions: Organize the mystery sentence. Read the sentences aloud. Check your pronunciation with your instructor.

1. The / . / is / she / Fruit / recorded / song / anti-lynching / ballad / another / Strange
2. movement / Rights / of / became / slaves, / Civil / descendant / the / a / . / Simone, / Nina / in / an / activist
3. civil / rights / . / disheartened / lost / Nina / Simone / was / steam, / the / movement / When
4. mark / a / , / Nina / world / of / left / Despite / on / . / Simone / adversity / music / the
5. to / she / . / life / France / peripatetic / settle / in / led / decided / She / a / before





Extension Activity

Watch two performances of "My Baby Just Cares for Me" by Nina Simone.

Instructions: Complete the following steps. Fill in the Self-Assessment.

- Go online and watch two different performances of the song "My Baby Just Cares for Me".
- Try to understand and write down the lyrics.
- Discuss any differences you see or hear in the two performances that Simone gives with a partner.
- Describe how you felt while you were listening to the song.

Self-Assessment

Yes No

I listen to a song by Nina Simone.

☐ ☐

I write down the lyrics.

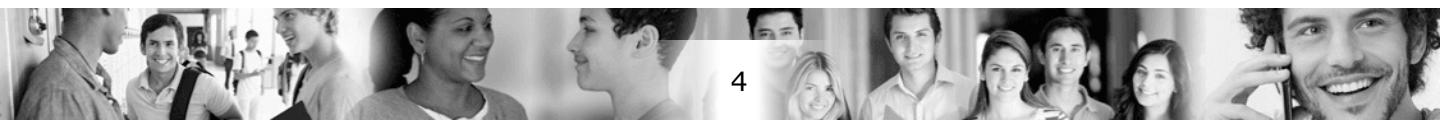
☐ ☐

I discuss what the song is about.

☐ ☐


Target Words

- **descendant** (noun): coming from an ancestor
e.g. Born on the 21st of February 1933, to the descendants of slaves, Nina Simone became a brilliant musician.
- **slave** (noun): a person who is the legal property of another and is forced to obey them
e.g. Born on the 21st of February 1933, to the descendants of slaves, Nina Simone became a brilliant musician.
- **anti-lynching** (adjective): against the practice of killing someone, especially by hanging, for an alleged offense without a legal trial
e.g. The anti-lynching ballad "Strange Fruit" is another song she recorded.
- **ballad** (noun): a poem or song narrating a story
e.g. The anti-lynching ballad "Strange Fruit" is another song she recorded.
- **to lose steam** (verb): to lessen in energy, enthusiasm, or importance
e.g. When the Civil Rights Movement lost steam, Nina Simone was disheartened and fed up.
- **peripatetic** (adjective): traveling from place to place, especially working or based in various places for relatively short periods
e.g. She led a peripatetic life before settling in the south of France.
- **adversity** (noun): difficulties; misfortune
e.g. Despite adversity, racism and poverty, Nina Simone left a mark on the world of music.
- **racism** (noun): prejudice, discrimination, or antagonism directed against someone of a different race
e.g. Despite adversity, racism and poverty, Nina Simone left a mark on the world of music.
- **improvisational** (adjective): not practiced or planned
e.g. In live concerts she was intimate, improvisational and raw.





Learning Points

Intonation with Non-Final Thought Groups

You can use intonation to help your speaking convey the meaning of what you want to say. Your intonation is influenced by the thought groups in the sentence.

In speaking, intonation refers to how you say what you say. It is the sound of your sentences, and it helps you to communicate more of what you mean, for example, sadness or anger.

When you divide sentences or speech into pieces that are semantically and grammatically coherent, these are called *thought groups*.

Thought groups are the groups of speech where the speaker can logically pause in the utterance. When you read a sentence, punctuation can help you decide when to pause and break up a sentence. However, there are times where a speaker may pause not based on punctuation.

These thought groups can influence pronunciation because in some sentences you have both rising and falling intonation.

Let's look at some sentences and figure out the intonation patterns.

I bought a new car.



Why did you come?



You use *falling intonation* at the end of statements or wh- questions.

Are you married?



You use *rising intonation* with yes/no questions.

In some sentences you can use non-final intonation. This means that there is rising intonation and then falling intonation within the sentence itself and not just at the end. This type of non-final intonation can be seen in sentences with unfinished thoughts, special words and phrases, a series of words or when talking about choices.

When I win the lottery, I'll buy a new car.



With unfinished thoughts, your rising intonation shows that you are still talking.





Learning Points

As far as I'm concerned, eating chocolate is healthy.

In my opinion, eating chocolate is healthy.

Other introductory phrases are *for example*, *by the way* and *actually*.

We need some eggs, milk, butter and flour.

With the series or items, the first few follow rising intonation and the last item has falling intonation.

Would you like coffee or tea?

You can talk about choices like offering alternatives in a question.

Examples:

- *As a matter of fact, Nina Simone was proclaimed the voice of the Civil Rights Movement.*
- *When the Civil Rights Movement lost steam, Nina Simone was disheartened and fed up.*





Learning Points

Vowel Reduction in Unstressed Syllables

You can improve your pronunciation by reducing vowels in syllables that are unstressed.

You can recognize which vowels to reduce if you notice that some syllables in words are not stressed. By reducing or shortening these vowels, your pronunciation of the word changes. When you reduce vowels in English, you reduce them to the *schwa*. Let's look at the following sentences.

Examples:

Ken has a broken watch.

Ken has a broken watch.

- the stress in "Ken" is different from in the word "broken"
- the stress falls on the first syllable of "broken" and the second syllable vowel is reduced so it sounds like /brokin/

"Come here!" commanded the lieutenant.

"Come here!" commanded the lieutenant.

- the stress in "come" is different from in the word "commanded"
- the stress falls on the second syllable of "commanded" so the first syllable vowel is reduced so it sounds like /cumandid/

Remember to make the stressed syllables longer and the unstressed syllables shorter.

Practice reading these examples:

Examples:

- *culture*
- *history*
- *written*
- *ballad*
- *before*
- *lecture*
- *cover*

